

Lateral root > These spindly roots branch out from the main taproots to form a complex, tangled network of roots.



Root hair > Tiny root hairs sprout from just above the growing tip of each root. They grow between soil particles and absorb the water and minerals that the plant needs to grow.

Root hairs grow from the root's skin cells (seen here in pink).

Types of roots



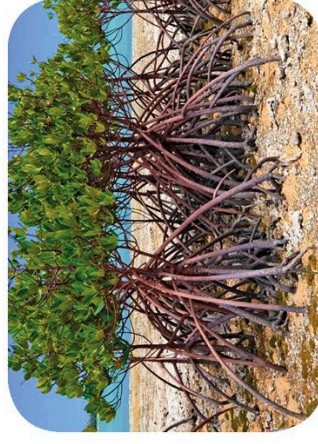
Aerial Some plants, typically in tropical forests, grow in the treetops with roots that cling to the tree bark for support. The American pearl laceleaf grows roots that hang in the moist air to absorb essential water.



Buttress Many tropical rain forest trees are supported by roots that spread out partly above the ground. This is because most rain forest soil is not very deep and these surface roots help anchor the tree.



Pneumatophore Rooted in waterlogged, airless mud, these mangrove trees grow in swampy, subtropical brackish (salty) water. Some have roots that grow upwards into the air to gather oxygen.



Stilt Mangroves growing on muddy tidal seashores are swept by waves at high tide. Many mangrove trees have stiltlike roots that arch down from their trunks to help support them in the moving water.